Japan, journeyed on to the Kansai region and consecrated a Buddhist temple in Nara. [27]

Trade and social interactions also took place in the first and early second millennium between India and its west. Trading networks that followed the seasonal monsoon winds linked India not just with the Arabian Peninsula and Red Sea, but with eastern and southern Africa. This included trade with east African ports such as Mogadishu, the Lamu archipelago, and Zanzibar. [28] The late first millennium saw East African exports of ivory, gold, and slaves to the Arabian Peninsula, Indian subcontinent, and further east. [29] Recent studies point to Indian women contributing to the gene pool of the Swahili coast in East Africa a thousand years ago, along with Persian men. [30] The same monsoon networks also brought trading and travelling communities from West Asia to India, including Christian, Jewish, Zoroastrian (Parsi), Armenian, and Arab communities to the Konkan, Malabar, and Coromandel coasts.

The Other Middle Kingdom: India and China, c. 200 BCE–1300 CE

An important part of these early Indo–Pacific trade networks was China. China was both a source of valuable commodities—especially silk—and a destination for traders, missionaries, and travellers. Ancient interactions between India and China are particularly well documented by Chinese sources but these must be considered carefully, for they often represent their own biases and worldviews.

An early impetus for initial China–India contacts was trade. The trade of cowrie shells, camphor, and silk via intermediaries dates back over 2500 years to the Shang period in China and the Vedic period in India. The Sanxingdui culture in today's Sichuan appears to have links with the Indian Ocean. Other early but indirect historical contacts date from the Han period, when the diplomat and explorer Zhang Qian, while in the vicinity of present-day Tajikistan or Afghanistan, found goods coming from a land called Shendu to the south, corresponding to one of the early Chinese